

Monday, June 29, 2026

1:00 p.m. – General Discussion

Commissioners Ron A. Smith, Chair; Colene M. Martin, Vice-Chair; Gary L. Richardson; Nikole Guzman, Recorder

Chair Ron Smith called the meeting to order at 1:00 p.m.

1. Declaration of Potential Conflicts of Interest

All Commissioners reviewed today's agenda, and it was determined that there are no conflicts of interest.

2. Murphy Irrigation District

Chair Smith opened discussion regarding the proposed removal of the Murphy Diversion Dam and invited representatives of the Murphy Irrigation District and interested parties to participate in an open discussion regarding the project. Commissioner Richardson stated that the purpose of the meeting was to better understand the proposed removal project, evaluate possible alternatives, and identify opportunities to preserve reliable irrigation service while addressing environmental concerns. Representatives of the Murphy Irrigation District, including **Thoren Halvorsen, Kevin Fay, Kristin Bryke, Andrea Applegate, Herman Berchiger, Sr., and Dave Combe**, participated throughout the discussion. Public Works Director **Rob Brandes** also provided historical information regarding the diversion structure and surrounding infrastructure.

Mr. Halvorsen reviewed the history of the Murphy Irrigation District's collaboration agreement with WaterWatch of Oregon, explaining that the District entered into negotiations after being advised that litigation was likely if an agreement could not be reached. Ms. Bryke discussed the legal framework surrounding the agreement, the permitting process, and the District's obligations under the negotiated settlement. Commissioners questioned whether additional alternatives remained available and discussed the financial challenges faced by the District in defending environmental litigation.

Discussion then shifted to the engineering aspects of the proposed project. Mr. Fay explained the proposed replacement of the existing gravity-fed diversion with a pumping system, describing anticipated operational changes, infrastructure improvements, maintenance requirements, and long-term operating costs. Commissioner Smith questioned whether relocating portions of the project to nearby County-owned property could simplify maintenance access and reduce future operational challenges. Participants also discussed whether portable pumping equipment or alternative configurations might better serve District patrons over the long term.

Commissioners and Murphy Irrigation District representatives discussed the economic impacts of converting to a pumping system. Mr. Halvorsen and Mr. Fay expressed concern that increasing electrical costs, equipment replacement, and ongoing maintenance expenses could substantially increase assessments to District patrons. Commissioner Richardson observed that rising operational costs could eventually reduce participation in the District, placing greater financial responsibility on remaining users and potentially affecting the long-term sustainability of irrigated agriculture within the Murphy area.

Environmental considerations were also discussed. Mr. Combe shared observations regarding fish passage at the existing diversion structure and questioned whether available biological information demonstrated that removal of the diversion would significantly improve fish habitat. Commissioners discussed previous diversion removal projects within Southern Oregon and questioned whether additional scientific evaluation would be beneficial before permanently removing the existing diversion.

Ms. Applegate described her family's long history along the Applegate River and discussed the importance of dependable irrigation to local agricultural operations and rural property owners. Mr. Berchiger shared similar concerns, emphasizing the value of preserving affordable irrigation for family farms and expressing concern that long-term operating costs associated with the proposed pumping system could become burdensome for future generations.

Public Works Director Rob Brandes provided historical perspective regarding the diversion structure and surrounding infrastructure based upon his experience with Josephine County Public Works. Discussion included historical maintenance activities, previous County involvement in the area, roadway access, and engineering considerations associated with the existing diversion.

Throughout the discussion, Commissioners expressed appreciation for the information provided by Murphy Irrigation District representatives and agreed that additional evaluation of potential alternatives may be appropriate before the project proceeds. The Board discussed opportunities for continued coordination with state and federal agencies, Murphy Irrigation District representatives, and other interested stakeholders to identify solutions that preserve reliable irrigation service while addressing environmental and regulatory concerns.

3. Other

None heard

4. Additional Subject Matters from Commissioners/Announcements

None heard

The meeting adjourned at 2:30 p.m.